LITERATURE

Introduction to Human Sciences
Feb 12, 16/19, 2026
IIIT Hyderabad

Agenda

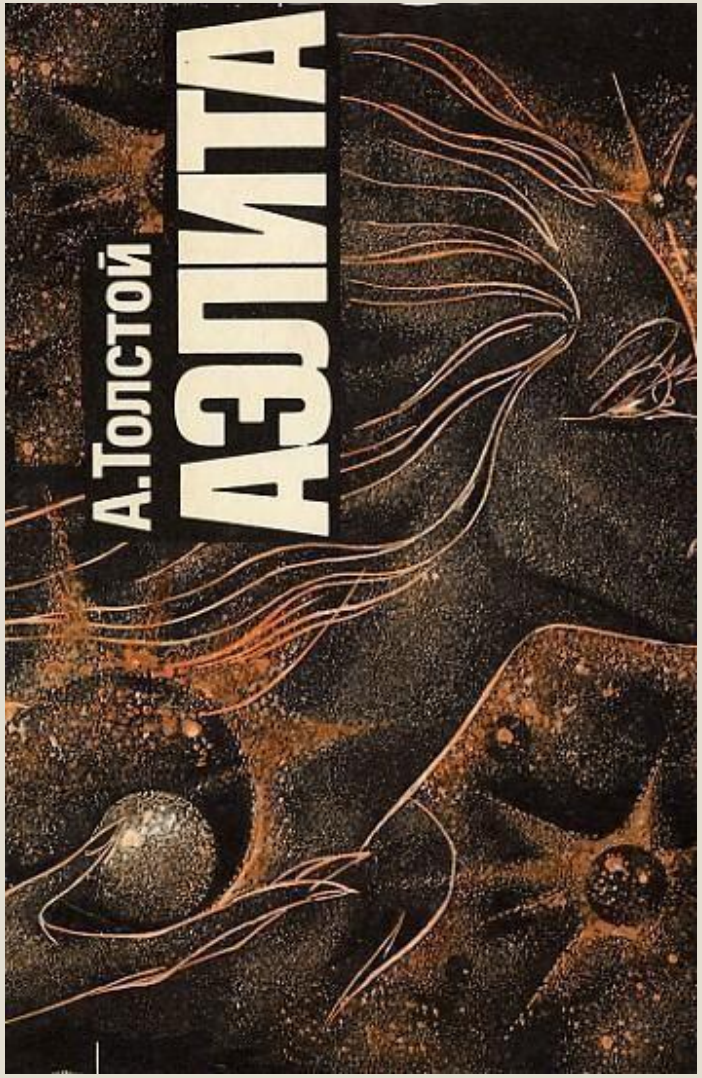
- Readings:
  1. Ray Bradbury, “There Will Come Soft Rains” (1950)
  2. Terry Eagleton, *How to Read Literature* (2013), chapter 1

What is it that literary scholars do? What do they study, and how do they study it?

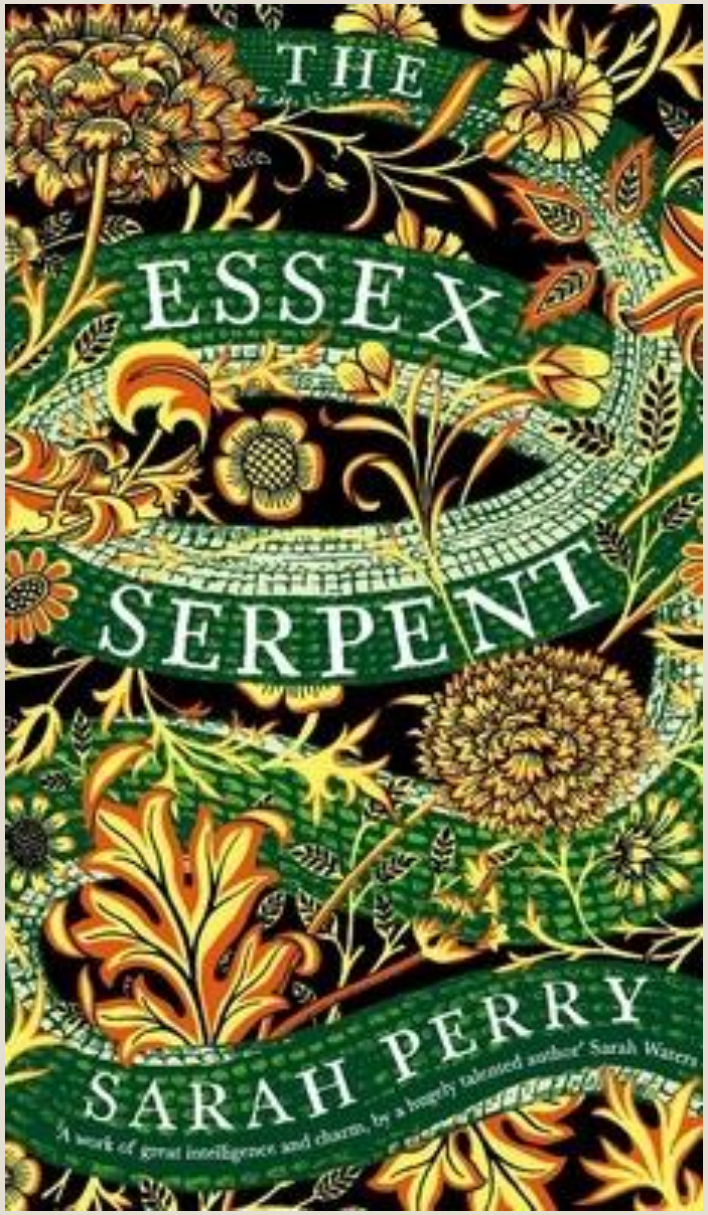
What do literary scholars study?

- **Human creative expression**, usually in the form of writing.
- This is also called **Literature**.
- **Fiction allows you to imagine other worlds**, puts us into someone else's shoes, allows access to experiences we will never directly access.

What would life be like a thousand years from now on another planet when technology has reached its zenith?



How did Victorian British society react to a wandering widowed woman of science who did not believe in "dragons"?



What do literary scholars study?

- Literature **voices/expresses (represents) the human condition**.
- There are **other imaginations** of the human experience apart from ours: some around us, some distant from us.

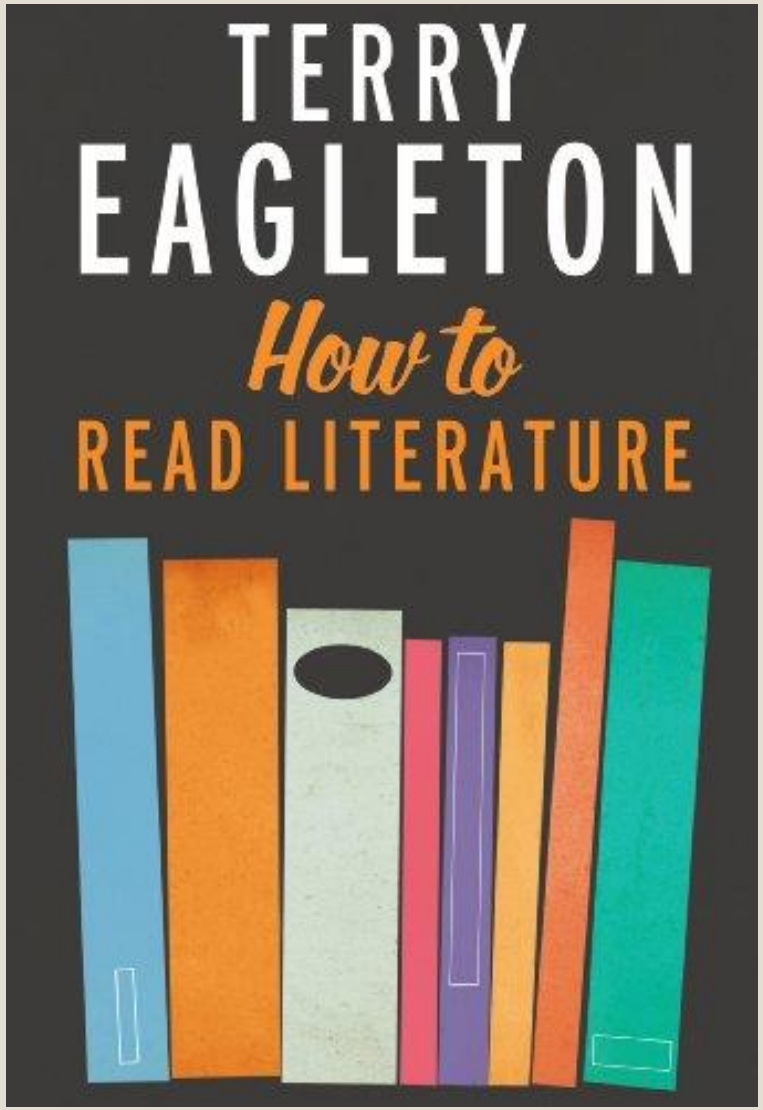
What do literary scholars study?

- As literary scholars, we **think critically, interpretively, creatively, imaginatively**
  - What is written? How is it written? What are the different ways in which it can be read? What are its possibilities?
  - **Fiction allows you to imagine**
- Put questions to fiction and interpret it to examine the human condition

What do literary scholars study?

- The meaning of a literary text – the truth it contains about human experience – is incomplete without the reader.
  - Each reader comes to a text from their own location.
  - Each reader invests a text with meaning.
  - The strength of an interpretation depends on what is made available/possible by a text.

READING 2:



Chapter 1, "Openings"

"The most common mistake students of literature make is to go straight for what the poem or novel says, setting aside the way that it says it. To read like this is to set aside the 'literariness' of the work – the fact that it is a poem or play or novel, rather than an account of the incidence of soil erosion in Nebraska. Literary works are pieces of rhetoric as well as reports. They demand a peculiarly vigilant kind of reading, one which is alert to tone, mood, pace, genre, syntax, grammar, texture, rhythm, narrative structure, punctuation, ambiguity – in fact to everything that comes under the heading of 'form'" (2).

“Part of what we mean by a ‘literary’ work is one in which *what* is said is to be taken in terms of *how* it is said. It is the kind of writing in which the content is inseparable from the language in which it is presented. Language is constitutive of the reality or experience, rather than simply a vehicle for it” (3).

“There Will Come Soft Rains” (1950)

Ask Questions of the Text

- What does the title mean? What does it signify?
- Why are some words in italics and others not in italics?
- Where are the people who live in the house? Where has everyone gone?
- What is special/different about this day? **"Until this day, how well the house had kept its peace."**

Ask Questions of the Text

- The incinerator is referred to as "Evil Baal." What might the author be trying to say?
- How/Why does the dog die? Who/what ensures its death and how?
- What purpose does the poem serve?
- So much of the figurative language of destruction (of the house) is from nature. Why?
- Why write a story like this in 1950?

Search for and Observe Patterns

- **Sing-song Repetition:** “Eight-one, tick-tock, eight-one o'clock, off to school, off to work, run, run, eight-one!”
- **Abounds in words (verbs) related to Sound and Touch:** tapped, sang quietly, whirling, whirred, thudded; Touch: soft tread, kneading.
- **Ending:** contrast between sun shining serenely and unfailingly, while the intelligent house, creation of humanity, is breaking down and just keeps repeating itself.

The House as Sentient Entity

- Until this day, how well the house had kept its peace. How carefully it had inquired, "Who goes there? What's the password?" and, getting no answer from lonely foxes and whining cats, it had shut up its windows and drawn shades in an old-maidenly preoccupation with self-protection which bordered on a mechanical paranoia.

It quivered at each sound, the house did. If a sparrow brushed a window, the shade snapped up. The bird, startled, flew off! No, not even a bird must touch the house!

- "The dog ran upstairs, hysterically yelping to each door, at last realizing, <u>as the house realized</u>, that only silence was here."
- "The house tried to save itself."
- "In the living room the voice-clock sang, Tick-tock, seven o'clock, time to get up, time to get up, seven o 'clock! as if it were afraid that nobody would."

The House as Sentient Entity

- “The house shuddered, oak bone on bone, its bared skeleton cringing from the heat, its wire, its nerves revealed as if a surgeon had torn the skin off to let the red veins and capillaries quiver in the scalded air. Help, help! Fire! Run, run! Heat snapped mirrors like the first brittle winter ice. And the voices wailed. Fire, fire, run, run, like a tragic nursery rhyme, a dozen voices, high, low, like children dying in a forest, alone, alone. And the voices fading as the wires popped their sheathings like hot chestnuts. One, two, three, four, five voices died.”

Who is the Narrator?

Third-person detached, unintrusive, economical observer, narrating as if reporting from the site.

- "Ten o'clock. The sun came out from behind the rain. The house stood alone in a city of rubble and ashes. This was the one house left standing. At night the ruined city gave off a radioactive glow which could be seen for miles."
- "Cleaning solvent, bottled, shattered over the stove. The room was ablaze in an instant!"
- "Smoke and silence. A great quantity of smoke."

Language

- ***Imagery***
  - "The garden sprinklers whirled up in golden founts, filling the soft morning air with scatterings of brightness. The water pelted window panes, running down the charred west side where the house had been burned, evenly free of its white paint."
  - "The gentle sprinkler rain filled the garden with falling light."

Evil Baal / Poetry as Prophecy

- "In the last instant under the fire avalanche, other choruses, oblivious, could be heard announcing the time, cutting the lawn by remote-control mower, or setting an umbrella frantically out and in, the slamming and opening front door, a thousand things happening, like a clock shop when each clock strikes the hour insanely before or after the other, a scene of maniac confusion, yet unity; singing, screaming, a few last cleaning mice darting bravely out to carry the horrid ashes away! And one voice, with sublime disregard for the situation, read poetry aloud in the fiery study, until all the film spools burned, until all the wires withered and the circuits cracked."
- "In the kitchen, an instant before the rain of fire and timber, the stove could be seen making breakfasts at a psychopathic rate, ten dozen eggs, six loaves of toast, twenty dozen bacon strips, which, eaten by fire, started the stove working again, hysterically hissing!"

Ask Big Questions

- Why present the house as a sentient entity in a scene of total human and material annihilation?
- Why anthropomorphize all the little gadgets, devices in the house? Why anthropomorphize nature?
- What purpose does such a narrator serve in such a text?
- How does the specific use of language in this text contribute to its larger vision/message?
- Reflection: what does it mean to be human in the age of AI?